

The Beginnings of Indian Civilisation

1. What is a Civilisation?

A civilisation is an advanced stage of human society characterized by:

- Government and administration
 - Planned cities (urbanism)
 - Various crafts and industries
 - Internal and external trade
 - Writing system
 - Cultural and religious traditions
 - Productive agriculture
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2. Indus-Sarasvatī (Harappan) Civilisation

- Earliest civilisation of the Indian Subcontinent.
 - Also called:
 - Harappan Civilisation
 - Indus Civilisation
 - Indus-Sarasvatī Civilisation
 - Sindhu-Sarasvatī Civilisation
 - Flourished between 2600 BCE and 1900 BCE.
 - First Urbanisation of India.
 - Named after Harappa, the first excavated site (1920–21).
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3. Geographical Extent

- Spread across present-day:
 - India
 - Pakistan
- Developed mainly along:

- Indus River and its tributaries
- Sarasvatī (Ghaggar-Hakra) River

Important Cities

City	Present Region
Harappa	Punjab (Pakistan)
Mohenjo-daro	Sindh (Pakistan)
Dholavira	Gujarat
Rakhigarhi	Haryana
Kalibangan	Rajasthan
Lothal	Gujarat

4. Town Planning

Harappan cities were highly planned:

- **Wide streets arranged in a grid pattern.**
- **Streets often aligned with cardinal directions.**
- **Cities divided into:**
 - **Upper Town (elite area)**
 - **Lower Town (common people)**
- **Strong fortifications around cities.**
- **Houses built with baked bricks.**
- **Similar construction quality for rich and poor.**

Great Bath (Mohenjo-daro)

- **Size: approximately 12 m × 7 m.**
- **Waterproofed using bitumen.**
- **Possibly used for religious rituals or elite bathing.**

5. Water Management

A major achievement of the Harappans.

Features:

- Individual bathrooms in houses.
- Underground drainage system.
- Hundreds of wells in cities.
- Large reservoirs for storing water.

Dholavira

- Had at least six large reservoirs.
 - Largest reservoir: 73 metres long.
 - Efficient rainwater harvesting system.
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6. Agriculture and Food

Crops Grown

- Wheat
- Barley
- Millets
- Rice (in some regions)
- Pulses
- Vegetables

Special Achievement

- First people in Eurasia to cultivate cotton.

Animals

- Domesticated animals for meat.
- Fishing in rivers and sea.

Evidence from Pots

Food remains found include:

- Dairy products
- Turmeric
- Ginger
- Banana

7. Trade and Crafts

Trade

- **Internal and external trade.**
- **Trade with regions such as:**
 - **Iran**
 - **Oman**
 - **Mesopotamia**

Exports

- **Carnelian beads**
- **Cotton**
- **Timber**
- **Ornaments**
- **Ivory products**

Imports

- **Copper and other materials.**

Dockyard at Lothal

- **One of the world's earliest dockyards.**
- **Used for maritime trade.**

8. Technology and Metallurgy

Metals Used

- **Copper**
- **Bronze (Copper + Tin)**

Objects Made

- **Tools**
- **Pots and pans**
- **Ornaments**
- **Figurines**

9. Harappan Seals and Writing

- **Made mostly from steatite.**
 - **Carried:**
 - **Animal figures (bull, unicorn, tiger, etc.)**
 - **Writing symbols**
 - **Used mainly for trade and identification.**
 - **Script remains undeciphered.**
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10. Art and Culture

Important Artefacts

- **Dancing Girl (bronze figurine)**
- **Priest King statue**
- **Terracotta figurines**
- **Swastika seal**
- **Three-faced deity seal**

Daily Life Objects

- **Mirrors**
 - **Weights**
 - **Chisels**
 - **Pots**
 - **Toys**
 - **Whistles**
 - **Board games**
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11. Decline of the Civilisation

Around 1900 BCE, cities began to decline.

Main Reasons

- 1. Climate Change**

- **Reduced rainfall.**
- **Agricultural difficulties.**

2. Drying of the Sarasvatī River

- **Settlements dependent on the river were abandoned.**

Important Fact

- **No evidence of invasion or major warfare has been found.**
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12. Legacy of the Harappans

The Harappans left behind:

- **Advanced town planning**
- **Drainage systems**
- **Water conservation techniques**
- **Trade networks**
- **Agricultural knowledge**
- **Craftsmanship and cultural traditions**

Many of these ideas influenced later phases of Indian civilisation